

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 714

By Powers

A RESOLUTION to recognize Jo Bruce on the occasion of her retirement.

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that we should honor those citizens who have performed with uncommon devotion and enthusiasm throughout their years of industry; and

WHEREAS, Jo Bruce is one such estimable person, who has served with distinction for thirty-one years as the Director of the Oak Ridge Schools Family Resource Center in Oak Ridge. It is one of the original thirteen Family Resource Centers established by the State of Tennessee in the fall of 1993, and Ms. Bruce has held the position since the inception of the program; and

WHEREAS, in her role as director, Ms. Bruce has focused on and established an extensive knowledge of the many resources available for families and children in order to help them access as many resources as possible; and

WHEREAS, prior to her current position in Oak Ridge, she began her career with the Tennessee Department of Human Services (now the Department of Children's Services) as a case manager. Her work included investigations, court interactions, placements into foster care, and reunification of children and families, as well as managing foster care home and adoption services; and

WHEREAS, she also previously worked in education, both as a preschool teacher in Mississippi and as a parent educator for Campbell County Schools in Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Bruce has received extensive training in the areas of the effects of poverty on development and the rewards of quality parent engagement and thus has been a presenter at state and local levels on these topics; and

WHEREAS, school safety and trauma recovery are priorities for Ms. Bruce, and she has used her experience to present on these topics in Tennessee and throughout the country,

working with dedication on the SAVE (Schools Against Violence in Education) Act to put policies and procedures in place to help keep children and school staff safe; and

WHEREAS, her commitment to her community extends to countless years of service on a number of area nonprofit boards, including Aid to Distressed Families of Appalachian Counties (ADFAC), United Way, Children's Advocacy Network, Emory Valley Center, TORCH, Blossom Center, DCS CAB, and the YWCA; and

WHEREAS, no stranger to awards and accolades, she has received the Bill Wilcox Box Tie Award from the ADFAC, the Patriotic Civilian Service Award, the United Way Starfish Award, the ADFAC Silent Hero Award, and numerous school-related awards and acknowledgments at both local and state levels; and

WHEREAS, a native daughter of Tennessee, Jo Bruce was born on January 14, 1956, to Ray and Maxine Bramlett and grew up in Jasper alongside her older brother, Larry; and

WHEREAS, after graduating fourth in her class from Marion County High School in 1974, Ms. Bruce enrolled in Middle Tennessee State University (MTSU) on a full scholarship, where she pursued a dual major of social work and psychology with a minor in criminal justice, receiving her degree in 1978; and

WHEREAS, during college, she met the love of her life, Ken Bruce, at a Delta Tau Delta party. He was the president of the MTSU chapter of Delta Tau Delta, and she was honored to become the Princess of the fraternity's Little Sisters; and

WHEREAS, Jo and Ken Bruce were married on June 23, 1979, at Falling Waters Baptist Church in Hixson; their marriage and Mr. Bruce's career in the United States Army carried them to many "homes" around the world, including Tracy City, Tennessee; Fort Sill, Oklahoma; Bremerhaven, Germany; Fort Riley, Kansas; Osterholz-Scharmbeck, West Germany; Fort Leavenworth, Kansas; and Ole Miss ROTC, Oxford, Mississippi, with some short tours to West Point, New York; San Antonio, Texas; and Charleston, South Carolina; and

WHEREAS, the Bruces enjoyed traveling throughout Europe, including West Germany, East Germany, Italy, Austria, Switzerland, Belgium, Denmark, France, and the Netherlands; and

WHEREAS, the happy couple welcomed two sons: Christopher Scott in 1980 and Patrick Alan in 1984. Chris is married to Tiffany Johnson, and Patrick is married to Sheryl Hunt. Jo Bruce dotes on and enjoys her four grandchildren, Ainsley, Brynn, William, and Kenneth; and

WHEREAS, today, Jo Bruce, widowed in 2005, lives in LaFollette and is an active member of Our Lady of Perpetual Help Catholic Church, where she has served on the Parish Council and the Social Justice Committee, taught confirmation classes, and shared her beautiful voice as a soloist in the choir; and

WHEREAS, Jo Bruce epitomizes the spirit and commitment that are characteristic of a true Tennessean; and

WHEREAS, throughout her estimable career, Jo Bruce has demonstrated the utmost professionalism, ability, and integrity, winning the unbridled respect and admiration of her colleagues, her community, and the State of Tennessee; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we extend to Jo Bruce our heartfelt wishes for a happy and fulfilling retirement and every continued success in her future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.